

5G, a healthcare professional could operate on a patient located on a different continent. The report says that this would be done through equipment that mimics the healthcare professional's movements instantaneously. "Robotic surgeries, deep healthcare management in rural areas and distribution of our centres of excellence, virtual teaching and participative experiments, everything can be done in a distributed way because of 5G," Sunil Bharti Mittal, Founder & Chairman of Bharti Enterprises, had told *BT* at the India@100 Summit. And in December 2022, as a taste of things to come, Bharti Airtel and Apollo Hospitals successfully carried out 5G-driven, AI-guided colonoscopy trials.

The PwC report also states that through the use of multiple health sensors, 5G minimises the time, cost and effort involved in R&D trials by ensuring the seamless flow of information from the patient to the provider and then on to research labs.

Besides 5G, another factor that could affect what the sector looks like in 2047 could be omics—collective technologies used to characterise and quantify pools of biological molecules and to explore their roles, relationships and actions. "The service can accelerate drug discovery and development to create cures for patients. It can also transform care by identifying the best treatment or prevention for patients. With the help of genomic data, clinicians can profile individual patients' tumors or circulating markers in blood and take decisions at the point of care. Usage of technology can bring personalised treatment options for cancer patients even in India," says Dr Rowland Illing, Director & Chief Medical Officer for International Public Sector Health at AWS. Some parts of the world are already using this service. For instance, Amazon Omics by AWS is currently available in Singapore in the Asia-Pacific region.

Panigrahi of Fortis adds that going forward, patients will be treated based on their genetic profile. "EMRs will help us gather patients' data and this will be the base on which AI will come into play, directing us on appropriate treatment modalities."

Going forward, wider application of 'humanless' systems and tech is expected in the healthcare space, says a report by PwC

THE DEVELOPMENT OF the healthtech sector could be key to the transformation of the healthcare space. According to a report by RBSA Advisors, the Indian healthtech market is expected to grow at a CAGR of 39 per cent and touch \$50 billion by 2033. The market, which comprises six segments—tele-medicine, e-pharmacy, fitness, wellness, healthcare IT, analytics, home healthcare and personal health management—is currently worth about \$2 billion, making up less than 1 per cent of the overall healthcare industry in India, says the report. "Wider application of robotics, machine

learning and AI, wearables and on-body devices, blockchain, among others, are going to change the future of healthcare. Cloud infrastructure in healthcare record maintenance and increased focus on digitalisation of patient healthcare records is likely to accelerate further," it says.

The application of robotics is growing rapidly in the healthcare and medical industry and going forward, wider application of 'humanless' systems and technology is expected, especially in surgery, prosthetics, therapeutics, healthcare logistics and pharma manufacturing, among others. 3D bio-printing will find its ap-

plication in drug testing, living human tissue production, medical research and development, says the report.

But what about funding? "Healthcare booking platforms, healthcare IT and fitness & wellness tech are the top segments in the healthtech sector that have received the highest funding in 2022... Even though there is a decline in funding in 2022 as compared to 2021, funding in the sector is still higher than the pre-pandemic levels," says Neha Singh, Co-founder of Tracxn, a capital markets company. "The healthtech sector in India can prove to be a big opportunity for investors in the future."

The healthcare sector, therefore, is poised for growth in the next two and a half decades, powered by tech. Good health, indeed, will be good business. **BT**

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